Putting on Tzitzit (Tallit)

Check the strings for damage before putting on a tallit. Hold the tallit and say Psalm 104:1–2, say the blessing, and wrap yourself (with a tallit gadol, the head and body are covered). Then say Mah Yakar. Mizrahi-Sephardic custom.

Before wrapping — Psalm 104:1–2

בָּרְכִי נַפְשִׁי אֶת יְהוָה, יְהוָה אֱלֹהַי
גָּדַלְתָּ מְאֹד, הוֹד וְהָדָר לָבָשְׁתָּ.
עֹטֶה אוֹר כַּשַּׂלְמָה, נוֹטֶה שָׁמַיִם
כַּיְרִיעָה.

bahr-KHEE nahf-SHEE eht
ah-doh-NIGH, ah-doh-NIGH
eh-loh-HIGH gah-DAHL-tah
meh-OHD, hohd veh-hah-DAHR
lah-VAHSH-tah. oh-TEH ohr
kah-sahl-MAH, noh-TEH
shah-MAH-yeem
kah-yeh-ree-AH.

Blessing — tallit gadol (large tallit)

Say standing, then wrap yourself.

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ
הָעוֹלָם, אֲשֶׁר קִדְּשָׁנוּ בְּמִצְוֹתָיו
וְצִוָּנוּ לְהִתְעַטֵּף בַּצִּיצִית.

bah-ROOKH ah-TAH
ah-doh-NIGH eh-loh-HAY-noo
MEH-lekh hah-oh-LAHM,
ah-SHER kee-deh-SHAH-noo
beh-meetz-voh-TAHV
veh-tzee-VAH-noo
leh-heet-ah-TEF bah-tzee-TZEET.

Blessing — tallit katan (small tallit worn under the clothing)

Say this blessing instead when putting on a tallit katan.

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ
הָעוֹלָם, אֲשֶׁר קִדְּשָׁנוּ בְּמִצְוֹתָיו
וְצִוָּנוּ עַל מִצְוַת צִיצִית.

bah-ROOKH ah-TAH
ah-doh-NIGH eh-loh-HAY-noo
MEH-lekh hah-oh-LAHM,
ah-SHER kee-deh-SHAH-noo
beh-meetz-voh-TAHV
veh-tzee-VAH-noo ahl
meetz-VAHT tzee-TZEET.

After wrapping — Mah Yakar (Psalm 36:8–11)

מַה יָּקָר חַסְדְּךָ אֱלֹהִים, וּבְנֵי אָדָם
בְּצֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ יֶחֱסָיוּן. יִרְוְיֻן מִדֶּשֶׁן
בֵּיתֶךָ, וְנַחַל עֲדָנֶיךָ תַשְׁקֵם. כִּי
עִמְּךָ מְקוֹר חַיִּים, בְּאוֹרְךָ נִרְאֶה
אוֹר. מְשֹׁךְ חַסְדְּךָ לְיֹדְעֶיךָ,
וְצִדְקָתְךָ לְיִשְׁרֵי לֵב.

mah yah-KAHR
khahs-deh-KHAH eh-loh-HEEM,
oov-NAY ah-DAHM beh-TZEL
keh-nah-feh-KHAH
yeh-kheh-sah-YOON.
yeer-veh-YOON mee-DEH-shen
bay-teh-KHAH, veh-NAH-khahl
ah-dah-neh-KHAH tahsh-KEM.
kee ee-meh-KHAH meh-KOHR
khah-YEEM, beh-oh-reh-KHAH
neer-EH ohr. meh-SHOHKH
khahs-deh-KHAH
leh-yohd-eh-KHAH,
veh-tzeed-kaht-KHAH
leh-yeesh-RAY layv.

Putting on Tefillin

Put on the arm tefillin first, then the head tefillin, and do not speak in between. Sephardic custom follows the Shulchan Aruch: one blessing, said on the arm tefillin, covers both. Ashkenazim add a second blessing on the head tefillin and say Barukh Shem; some Sephardic communities also say the second blessing. Follow your rav.

Arm tefillin — blessing

Say it as you place the tefillin on the arm, before tightening the strap.

> bah-ROOKH ah-TAH
> ah-doh-NIGH eh-loh-HAY-noo
> MEH-lekh hah-oh-LAHM,
> ah-SHER kee-deh-SHAH-noo
> beh-meetz-voh-TAHV
> veh-tzee-VAH-noo
> leh-hah-NEE-ahkh teh-fee-LEEN.

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ
הָעוֹלָם, אֲשֶׁר קִדְּשָׁנוּ בְּמִצְוֹתָיו
וְצִוָּנוּ לְהָנִיחַ תְּפִלִּין.

Head tefillin — blessing

Say this only if you spoke between the arm and head tefillin, or if your community says it every time.

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ
הָעוֹלָם, אֲשֶׁר קִדְּשָׁנוּ בְּמִצְוֹתָיו
וְצִוָּנוּ עַל מִצְוַת תְּפִלִּין.

bah-ROOKH ah-TAH
ah-doh-NIGH eh-loh-HAY-noo
MEH-lekh hah-oh-LAHM,
ah-SHER kee-deh-SHAH-noo
beh-meetz-voh-TAHV
veh-tzee-VAH-noo ahl
meetz-VAHT teh-fee-LEEN.

Winding the strap around the finger — Hosea 2:21–22

Said while winding the strap three times around the middle finger.

וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי לְעוֹלָם, וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי
בְּצֶדֶק וּבְמִשְׁפָּט וּבְחֶסֶד וּבְרַחֲמִים.
וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בֶּאֱמוּנָה, וְיָדַעַתְּ אֶת
יְהוָה.

veh-eh-rahs-TEEKH lee
leh-oh-LAHM,
veh-eh-rahs-TEEKH lee
beh-TZEH-dek oov-meesh-PAHT
oov-KHEH-sed
oov-rah-khah-MEEM.
veh-eh-rahs-TEEKH lee
beh-eh-moo-NAH,
veh-yah-DAH-aht eht
ah-doh-NIGH.

Mikvah — Women (Tevilat Niddah)

The blessing is said once. Mizrahi-Sephardic custom has two orders. The Shulchan Aruch and Rav Ovadia Yosef: say it before immersing, outside the water of the mikveh itself. The Ben Ish Chai (Iraqi custom): immerse once, say the blessing, then immerse again. Ask the mikveh attendant or your rav which your community follows.

Blessing

> bah-ROOKH ah-TAH
> ah-doh-NIGH eh-loh-HAY-noo
> MEH-lekh hah-oh-LAHM,
> ah-SHER kee-deh-SHAH-noo
> beh-meetz-voh-TAHV
> veh-tzee-VAH-noo ahl
> hah-teh-vee-LAH.

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ
הָעוֹלָם, אֲשֶׁר קִדְּשָׁנוּ בְּמִצְוֹתָיו
וְצִוָּנוּ עַל הַטְּבִילָה.

There is no set text for a personal prayer; many women add one in their own words.

Mikvah — Men

Men have no obligation to immerse today. Many immerse by custom before Shabbat and festivals, before Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, and before prayer. The usual practice is that no blessing is said on this immersion, and no set text is required. The verses below are commonly said. A convert is the exception: he or

she says the blessing “al hatevilah” (see the women’s entry) after emerging from the water.

Verses commonly said

וְזָרַקְתִּי עֲלֵיכֶם מַיִם טְהוֹרִים וּטְהַרְתֶּם, מִכֹּל טֻמְאוֹתֵיכֶם וּמִכָּל גִּלּוּלֵיכֶם אֲטַהֵר אֶתְכֶם.

veh-zah-RAHK-tee ah-lay-KHEM MAH-yeem teh-hoh-REEM oo-teh-hahr-TEM, mee-KOHL toom-oh-tay-KHEM oo-mee-KOHL gee-loo-lay-KHEM ah-tah-HER et-KHEM.

מִקְוֵה יִשְׂרָאֵל יְהוָה.

meek-VEH yees-rah-EL ah-doh-NIGH.